DBQ Point Guide 3: Evidence from the Documents

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What the rubric requires

Row C awards up to 2 points for document evidence, and they stack: point 1 for *describing* 3 documents, point 2 for *using* 4 documents to support an argument.

Point	Threshold	What counts
1st point	Content of **3+ documents**	Accurately describes — in the student's own words — what each document says, related to the prompt's topic.
2nd point	**4+ documents** support an argument	Each document's content is tied to a claim: "this shows X, which proves my point that Y."

A document doesn't count if the response:

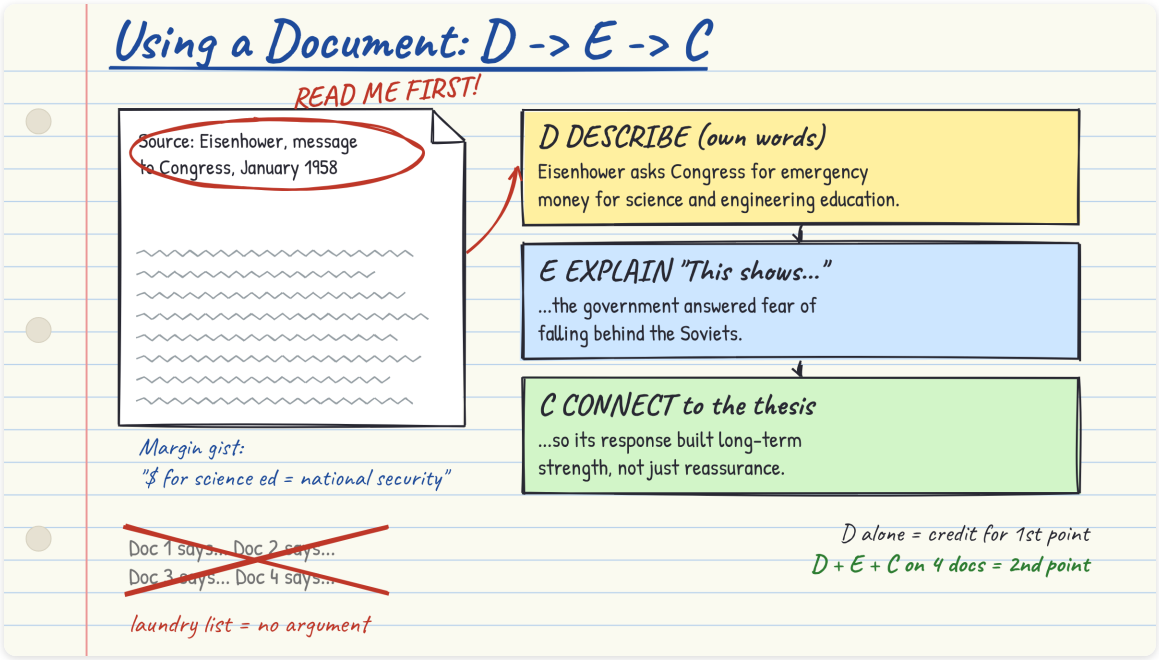
- **Only quotes it.** A quotation with no description in the student's words gets nothing.
- **Misinterprets it.** 2025 Set 1 Sample 1B lost Document 5 by claiming Goldwater supported Kennedy's programs.
- **Lumps documents together.** "Documents 1, 3, and 5 show that…" without explaining each one separately.
- **Only mentions it.** "As seen in Document 2…" with no content.

The four documents for the 2nd point don't have to support one argument. They can be spread across sub-arguments or used for a counterargument.

Calibration note: the 2023 samples were scored when the 2nd point required **six** documents. Under the current rubric (DBQ Rubric.pdf), 2023 Set 1 Sample 1B (four documents described) would still miss the 2nd point because Document 4 was only paraphrased, but 2023 Set 2 Sample 1C, with four documents used accurately, would likely earn it.

The foolproof formula

Every document a student uses gets the same three-part **D-E-C** sentence set:



1. **Describe** (earns point 1): put the document's content in your own words. "In Document B, Secretary of State Dulles warns that a communist takeover of any American state would endanger the whole free world."
2. **Explain** (bridges to point 2): say what that shows. "This shows that U.S. leaders saw even a small country like Guatemala as a Cold War front."
3. **Connect** (earns point 2): tie it to the thesis. "Fear of communism spreading next door drove the government to intervene abroad, which is one way it tried to calm Americans' fears."

Rules to drill:

- **One document per D-E-C.** Never "Docs A, C, and F all show…"; give each its own sentences.
- **Quote at most a phrase**, and always wrap it in your own description.
- **Use five, aim for seven.** Five gives one document of cushion if a reader rejects one. Seven well-used documents also earns the complexity point (Guide 6).
- **Check your reading.** Before using a document, write a 5-word gist in the margin. Misreading cost at least one document in six of the 18 College Board samples.
- **Label each document** ("Document E"), so the reader can credit it.

Examples that earned the points

Source	Docs used	What the commentary credited
2025 Set 2, Sample 1A (score 7)	All 7	Doc 1 supports an argument that the transcontinental railroad unified the regions and brought "economic stability"; Docs 2, 3, and 5 support a counterargument that industrialization deepened class division, shrank the middle class, and increased racism. Positive and negative sub-arguments both count.
2025 Set 1, Sample 1A (score 7)	3, 4, 5, 7	Exactly four docs, each tied to a claim: Doc 3 (highways primed economic growth), Doc 4 (social welfare as an engine of prosperity), Docs 5 and 7 (the New Right's turn to laissez-faire). Four is enough when each supports an argument.
2025 Set 2, Sample 1B (score 4)	1, 3, 4, 5	Earned both points despite a weak essay overall: Doc 1 shows railroads boosting interstate trade; Doc 3 shows monopolies causing class problems; Doc 4 shows a party divide; Doc 5 shows workers being "taken advantage of."
2024 Set 2, Sample 1B (score 5)	2, 3, 5, 6	Each document illustrates a different fear (Reds, immigrant spies, European entanglement, Japanese Americans) feeding the claim that Americans were "constantly suspicious."
2024 Set 1, Sample 1A (score 7)	1, 3, 4, 6	Doc 3 was **mislabeled as Document 4** and still credited, because the content was clearly described.

What a credited sentence looks like (College Board 2025 Set 2 example):

> "Kelley explained how the union label system developed in response to unsafe working conditions, which intensified as a result of industrialization in the late nineteenth century."

It describes the content (union labels respond to unsafe conditions) and connects it to an argument (organized labor responded to industrialization).

Cold War model (written for this guide):

> "In Document G, Eisenhower asks Congress for emergency federal money for science and engineering education because of 'the national security interest.' This shows the government answered fear of falling behind the Soviets by investing in schools, so its response targeted the source of the fear rather than just calming the public."

Examples that did not earn the points

Source	Result	Why documents were rejected
2024 Set 2, Sample 1C (score 3)	0 of 2	Only **one** document's content was used. Doc 2 was “only mentioned,” Doc 5 was misinterpreted, and the Doc 7 discussion covered only its historical situation, not its content. Sourcing a document is not the same as using its content.
2024 Set 1, Sample 1C (score 2)	0 of 2	Docs 1 and 5 were “simply mentioned.” Docs 1 and 2 were cited together, but only Doc 2's content was used.
2025 Set 2, Sample 1C (score 2)	1 of 2	Six documents discussed, Docs 3 and 4 described incorrectly, and **none** tied to an argument. Description earns point 1; without "this shows / this proves," point 2 is lost.
2025 Set 1, Sample 1C (score 2)	1 of 2	Described Docs 3, 4, and 6, but used none to support an argument.
2025 Set 1, Sample 1B (score 5)	2 of 2, but lost one doc	Doc 5 misread: claimed Goldwater supported Kennedy's programs, when he argued for less federal intervention. The essay still had four other docs.
2023 Set 2, Sample 1B (score 5)	Doc 4 rejected	Claimed “all people living in American-acquired territories would be granted U.S. citizenship”; the document says the opposite.

Describes, but doesn't use (College Board's own non-examples for point 2):

- “The political cartoon shows Teddy Roosevelt trying to control trusts, which are represented by a bronco.” (2025)
- “Document 1 discusses racial discrimination in New Deal programs.” (2025)

Both earn credit toward the 1st point. Neither says what the document *proves*.

Cold War non-examples (written for this guide):

- “Document A says 'There is too much hysteria.'” Quotation only.
- “Documents C, D, and F show the government responding to fear.” Lumped together.
- “Document D shows Americans loved road trips in the 1950s.” Misses that the highways were "Interstate and *Defense* Highways."

Expert tips (Heimler's History)

Reading the documents (about 15 minutes for all seven; THREE Secrets, 2024):

1. **Read the source line first.** It gives author, date, and context before you read a word. That speeds comprehension and sets up sourcing.
2. **Summarize each document's main idea in the margin**, in your own words, in a minute or two. This becomes the "Describe" sentence later.
3. **Group the documents into 2–3 categories** (economic, social, positive/negative). Not required by the rubric, but he calls it "often the difference between a high-scoring and a low-scoring essay." The groups become body paragraphs. The exam writers chose documents that fall into groups, so look for the connections (How to WRITE DBQs Faster).

Writing with them (A FORMULA for Writing a DBQ, 2024):

- **Topic sentence → Evidence → Analysis.** Take the topic sentence from a thesis category, describe a document in your own words, then start the next sentence with **"This shows…"** or **"This demonstrates…"** That's the D-E-C pattern above.
- **Avoid the laundry list.** "Document 1 says… Document 2 says… Document 3 says…" signals a writer who can't handle evidence and almost never scores high.
- **Don't over-quote.** At the AP Reading, a reader reported students who clearly understood a document and then lost the point by quoting instead of paraphrasing (Top 5 MISTAKES).
- **Write legibly.** Readers can't award points they can't read; fewer documents written clearly beats more written illegibly.

Rubric note: Heimler's 2024 videos use the current thresholds (3 described, 4 supporting). Older materials, including the 2023 samples here, used 6 for the second point.

Grader checklist

Tally each document the essay touches, then score.

Doc	Content described accurately in own words?	Used to support a claim?
A		
B		
C		
D		
E		
F		
G		

1. Strike any document that is only quoted, only mentioned, misread, or lumped with others.

2. **3+ in the first column = 1 point.**
3. **4+ in the second column = 2 points.** (The second column requires the first.)
4. **7 in the second column** = flag for the complexity point (Guide 6).

Feedback stems for students

- 1 of 2: "You described [n] documents accurately. To earn the second point, end each one with what it *proves* about your thesis: 'This shows…, which supports my claim that…'"
- Misread: "Re-read Document [X]: the author actually argues [correct gist]."